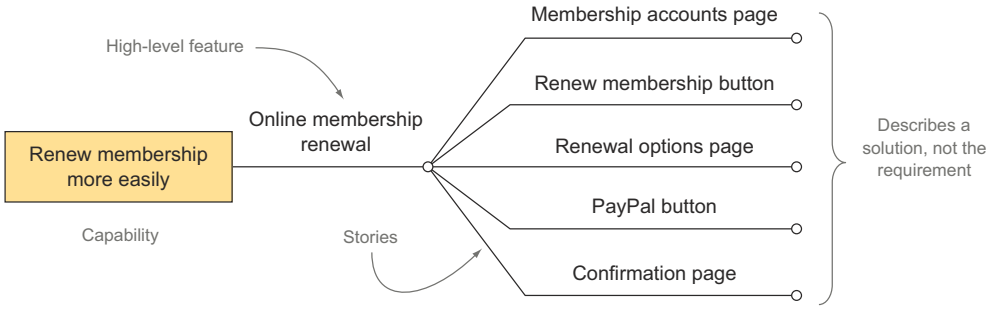



**Figure 4.8 It's dangerous to decompose features with a particular solution in mind.**

commit early to a given solution, and you can miss the opportunity to provide a more appropriate solution. In figure 4.8, for example, the ability to renew memberships using Frequent Flyer points has been forgotten in all the excitement around implementing a PayPal-based solution.

### 4.1.3 A feature can be described by one or more user stories

User stories are the bread and butter of Agile projects, and they've been around, in slightly differing forms, since the origins of Agile. A user story is a short description of something a user or stakeholder would like to achieve, expressed in language that the business can understand. For example, the following user story describes a requirement around forcing users to enter at least a moderately complex password when they register to be a Frequent Flyer member. For this story, you can use a format very similar to the ones used for features earlier on:

```
Story: Providing a secure password when registering
In order to avoid hackers compromising member accounts
As the systems administrator
I want new members to provide a secure password when they register
```

**This is the same format that you used for features.**

Agile practitioners are fond of emphasizing that a user story is not actually a requirement, but more a promise to have a conversation with the stakeholders about a requirement. Stories are a little like entries in a to-do list, giving you a general picture of what needs to be done, and reminding you to go ask about the details when you come to implement the story.

User stories are traditionally represented on story cards like the one in figure 4.9, which also includes other details, such as a priority and a rough estimate of size in some agreed metric (estimates are often in hours, or they may use the more abstract notion of "story points"). You can also use similar cards to represent features.

On the flip side of the card, you can put an initial list of acceptance criteria in simple bullet points (see figure 4.10). These acceptance criteria clarify the scope and boundaries of the story or feature. They help remove ambiguities, clarify assumptions, and build up the team's common understanding of the story or feature. They also act